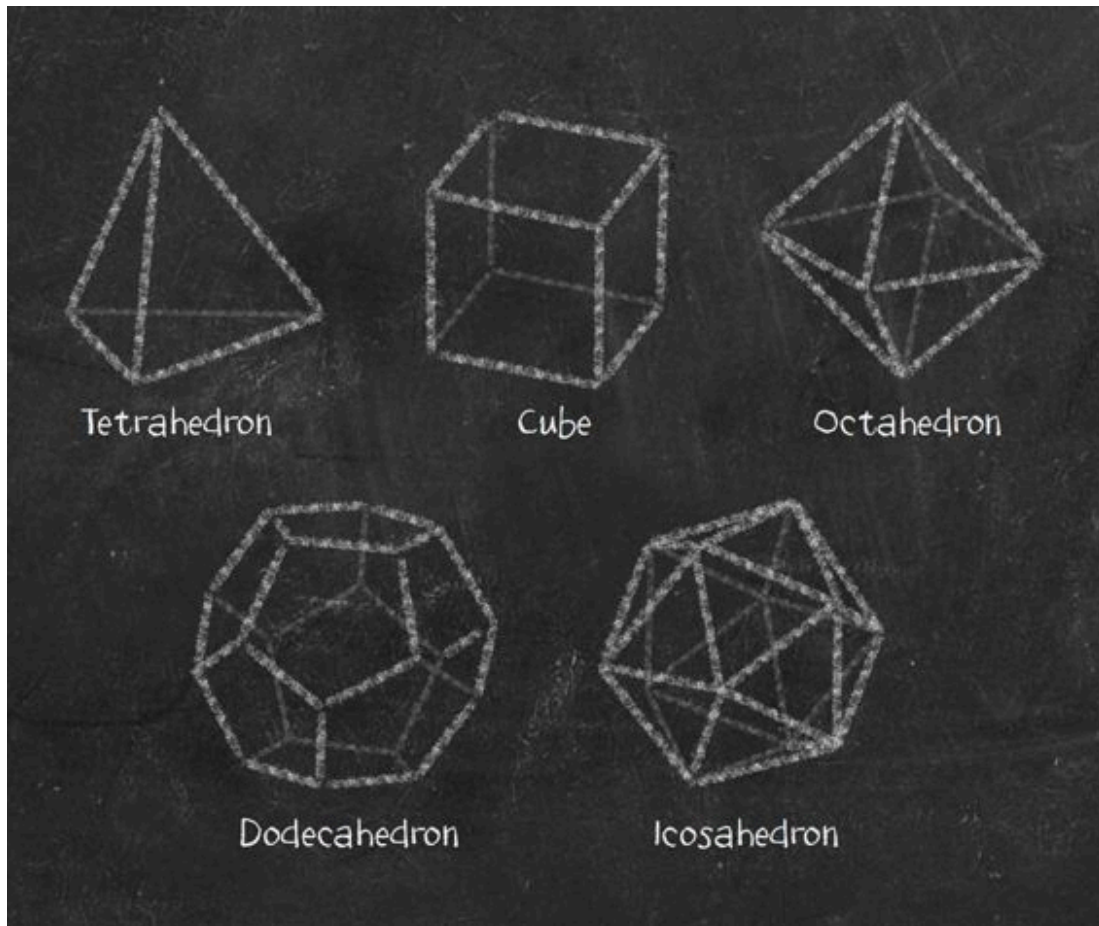


Plato's theory of Forms

Socrates's method of using dialectical questioning to establish the fundamental essence of a concept set Plato in the direction of one of his most important ideas, the theory of Forms or Ideas (given capital letters here to distinguish these from other meanings of the words). He, too, sought to find definitions, and find out what it is that makes a thing exactly the sort of thing that it is. When we see a bed, for example, we recognize it as a bed even though it may differ in many ways from all the beds we have ever seen. We have, Plato, argued, an idea of an ideal Form of *bed* in our minds. Similarly, we can recognize a circle, no matter how badly drawn, because we have in mind the Idea, or Form, of a perfect circle, even though such a thing cannot exist. There are also Forms for abstract concepts as well as concrete objects. These ideal Forms exist in a world separate from our earthly existence, but we have an innate knowledge of them that can be accessed by rational thought – in contrast to the imperfect perceptions available through our senses.



The regular geometrical shapes known as the Platonic solids were seen as some of the most perfect of all Forms.